deal. Only one sentence in Kennedy's memorandum on the meeting, three and a quarter pages in length, dealt with the secret part of his negotiations with Dobrynin. It concerned the time period after which the missiles should be withdrawn. Robert informed Rusk: "If some time elapsed—and per your instructions, I mentioned four to five months—I said I was sure that these matters could be resolved satisfactorily." In the copy of the memo available today, even that sentence has been crossed out.[16]

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ROBERT KENNEDY WAS BACK AT THE WHITE HOUSE AROUND 8:40 p.m., where he found his elder brother talking on the phone with his four-year-old daughter, Caroline. Together with her younger brother, John, and their mother, Jacqueline, Caroline was at the family estate of Glen Ora in Virginia. With a nuclear strike on DC and the White House becoming a distinct possibility, John Kennedy wanted his family to be outside the possible zone of destruction. Members of the administration would be evacuated in case of nuclear attack, but the wives and children of his aides would have to get out of DC on their own. Although he could take his family with him into evacuation, Kennedy wanted to save them the ordeal. Jacqueline's pleas to allow them to stay in DC that weekend were to no avail.[17]

Robert briefed John Kennedy on his rendezvous with the Soviet ambassador while sharing a meal with his brother and John's confidant and special assistant, David Powers. Powers was present at some of the ExCom meetings but always remained silent, having been charged by the president with the task of observing the scene and reporting his thoughts about Kennedy's performance and the dynamics in the room. Now Powers was eating a warmed-up chicken left by the kitchen staff for the president and drinking wine, while John and Robert Kennedy conversed. "God, Dave," said John Kennedy jokingly to his aide. "The way you're eating up all that chicken and drinking up all my wine, anybody would think it was your last meal." Powers was quick to respond: "The way Bobby's been talking, I thought it was my last meal."[18]